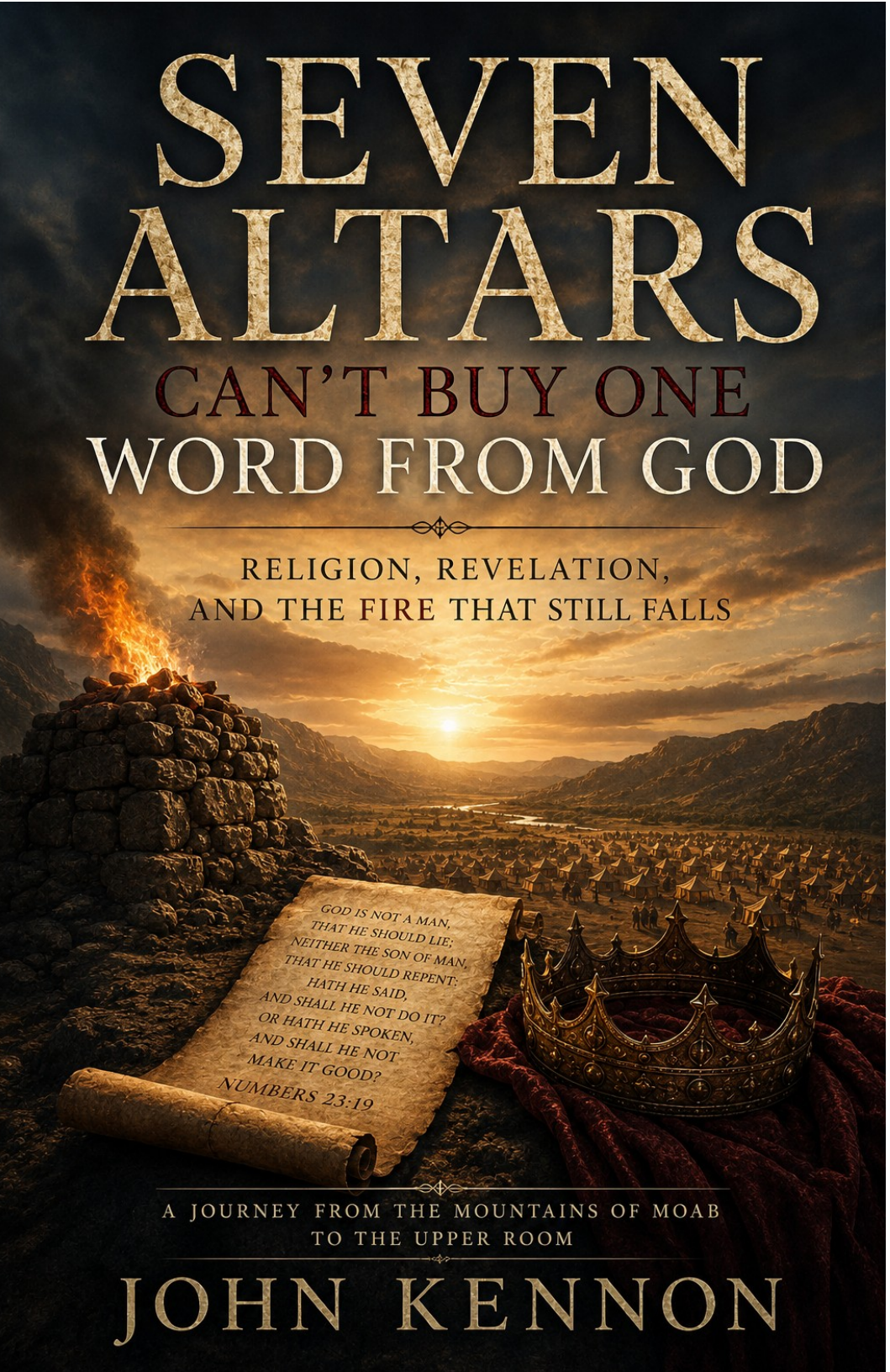
SEVEN ALTARS CAN'T BUY ONE WORD FROM GOD

RELIGION, REVELATION, AND THE FIRE THAT STILL FALLS



A JOURNEY FROM THE MOUNTAINS OF MOAB
TO THE UPPER ROOM

JOHN KENNON

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A Journey from the Mountains of Moab to the Upper Room

John P. Kennon

Opening Scripture

"Behold, I have received commandment to bless: and he hath blessed; and I cannot reverse it."

— Numbers 23:20

Author's Preface

There are moments in Scripture when God pulls back the curtain and allows us to see not merely the events of history, but the principles that govern His Kingdom. The account of Balaam and Balak is one of those moments. At first glance it appears to be the story of a frightened king, a reluctant prophet, and a series of sacrifices offered upon lonely mountains overlooking the plains of Moab. Yet beneath the surface lies one of the most profound revelations in all of Scripture.

This is not simply the story of seven altars.

It is the story of humanity's relentless attempt to reach God through its own effort, while God continually reveals that He cannot be manipulated by ambition, purchased through religion, or persuaded to violate His own Word.

Balak believed more altars would produce another answer.

God had already spoken.

Centuries later, another group of people gathered—not upon a mountain, but in an upper room in Jerusalem. They possessed no altars, no sacrifices, no priesthood, and no earthly power. They had only the promise of Jesus Christ and hearts humbled by revelation. They did not attempt to persuade heaven. They simply waited in obedient faith.

Then heaven came down. The contrast could not be greater.

One mountain was filled with smoke but no new word.

One room was filled with fire because God's final Word had already been revealed in Jesus Christ.

This book traces that journey. From the mountains of Moab to the cross. From the cross to the Upper Room. From the Upper Room to the Church. And from the Church to every heart that still longs for the fire of God to fall today.

For the central question has never changed.

Can religion bring man to God?

Or...

**Has God always intended to reveal Himself to those who humbly receive His Word?

The answer echoes from every page of Scripture.

Not by ambition. Not by manipulation. Not by human effort.

But by revelation.

Fear has built more altars than faith ever has. Throughout history, whenever men have believed God could be persuaded by human effort, mountains have filled with smoke but heaven has remained silent. Yet there is another way—a way not built upon ambition, but upon revelation. Our journey begins in the plains of

Moab, where a frightened king looked across a valley and mistook the presence of God's people for a political problem, never realizing he was about to confront the unchanging character of God.

Journey One

A King Standing on a Wall

Primary Text: Numbers 22:1–6

Balak Summons Balaam

Num 22:1 Then the people of Israel set out and camped in the plains of Moab beyond the Jordan at Jericho.

Num 22:2 And Balak the son of Zippor saw all that Israel had done to the Amorites.

Num 22:3 And Moab was in great dread of the people, because they were many. Moab was overcome with fear of the people of Israel.

Num 22:4 And Moab said to the elders of Midian, “This horde will now lick up all that is around us, as the ox licks up the grass of the field.” So Balak the son of Zippor, who was king of Moab at that time,

Num 22:5 sent messengers to Balaam the son of Beor at Pethor, which is near the River in the land of the people of Amaw, to call him, saying, “Behold, a people has come out of Egypt. They cover the face of the earth, and they are dwelling opposite me.

Num 22:6 Come now, curse this people for me, since they are too mighty for me. Perhaps I shall be able to defeat them and drive them from the land, for I know that he whom you bless is blessed, and he whom you curse is cursed.”

Supporting References: Genesis 12:1–3; Deuteronomy 2:9; Joshua 24:9–10; Micah 6:5

Literary Prelude

History is often remembered through the rise and fall of kingdoms, the victories of great armies, and the names of powerful rulers. Scripture, however, invites us to see history differently. Behind every throne stands a heart. Behind every battle stands a belief. Behind every decision stands a theology, whether true or false. Long before swords are drawn or treaties are signed, the deepest conflicts are fought within the unseen world of the human soul. Such is the case in the story that now unfolds upon the plains of Moab.

Few men ever intended to oppose God outright. More often, they simply misunderstood Him. Fear clouded their judgment, pride shaped their decisions, and ambition convinced them they could accomplish by their own strength what only the grace of God could ever provide. The tragedy of Balak is not merely that he was a pagan king. His tragedy was that he believed God could be approached like every other king—with enough gifts, enough persuasion, enough sacrifice, and enough effort.

The mountains of Moab would soon reveal how mistaken he was.

Historical Setting

The events recorded in Numbers 22 take place near the close of Israel's forty years of wilderness wandering. The generation that had departed from Egypt under Moses had nearly passed from the scene, and a new generation now stood upon the eastern side of the Jordan River opposite Jericho, looking toward the land God had promised to Abraham centuries before (Numbers 22:1; Genesis 12:1–3). Israel's years in the wilderness had not been years of aimless wandering alone; they had become years in which God shaped a covenant people, teaching them dependence, discipline, and trust.

During the final stages of that journey, Israel defeated two powerful Amorite kings—Sihon and Og (Numbers 21:21–35). These victories dramatically altered the political landscape east of the Jordan. News traveled quickly throughout the ancient Near East, and neighboring kingdoms watched with growing alarm as a nation of former slaves repeatedly overcame enemies far stronger than themselves. Their victories defied conventional military explanation.

Among those watching was Balak, the son of Zippor, king of Moab.

The Moabites traced their ancestry to Lot, Abraham's nephew (Genesis 19:30–38). Although related to Israel, the relationship between the two nations had long been

strained. Yet Scripture makes an important observation often overlooked by modern readers: Israel had not come to conquer Moab. In fact, God had expressly forbidden Israel from taking Moab's territory because He Himself had given that land to the descendants of Lot (Deuteronomy 2:9). The threat Balak perceived was not based upon Israel's stated intentions but upon his interpretation of Israel's presence.

Fear, after all, rarely waits for facts.

The Jewish historian Josephus records that Balak concluded Israel's victories could not be explained by military strength alone but by the supernatural favor resting upon them (*Antiquities of the Jews*, Book IV). Whether one consults Josephus or simply follows the biblical narrative, the conclusion remains the same: Balak was not ultimately afraid of Israel. He was afraid of Israel's God.

Enter the Story

Imagine standing beside Balak as the evening sun slowly settles beyond the western hills.

The king has climbed to one of the fortified heights overlooking the Jordan Valley. Below him stretches a landscape unlike anything he has ever witnessed. Where open plains once rolled quietly toward the river now stands an immense city of tents. Thousands of campfires flicker in the fading light as smoke rises

gently into the evening sky. Children weave between the rows of shelters while shepherds gather their flocks for the night. Mothers prepare the evening meal. Fathers speak quietly around small fires. The sounds of ordinary life drift upward upon the desert wind.

To anyone else, it might have appeared almost peaceful.

To Balak, it looked like the beginning of the end.

He had heard the stories, just as every king throughout the region had heard them. Egypt—the greatest empire on earth—had been brought to its knees without Israel possessing an army. The Nile had become blood. Darkness had swallowed the land. Death had entered Pharaoh's own household. Then came the impossible story of the sea dividing before an entire nation, allowing them to escape while Egypt's armies disappeared beneath the returning waters. Those stories were followed by reports from the wilderness: bread falling from heaven, water flowing from solid rock, and mighty kings falling before a people who had once lived as slaves.

Every report ended with the same conclusion.

Israel's God fought for His people.

Standing upon that mountain, Balak realized he was facing an enemy unlike any he had ever known. He did not fear Israel because of its military strength. He feared the unseen God who walked among them.

Without realizing it, the king had arrived at one of the greatest theological questions in all of Scripture:

What does a man do when he discovers there is a God greater than himself?

Opening the Text

Moses introduces the narrative with remarkable restraint: *"And Balak the son of Zippor saw all that Israel had done to the Amorites"* (Numbers 22:2). That single verb deserves careful attention. Balak **saw**. His actions were shaped by what he perceived. Scripture never records Israel threatening Moab, preparing an invasion, or violating the boundaries God Himself had established. Balak's fear grew, not from divine revelation, but from human interpretation.

Fear has always distorted vision.

Throughout Scripture it causes men to imagine dangers where faith sees opportunity. It convinces the heart that immediate action is wiser than patient trust. Fear rarely produces surrender; it almost always produces control. It seeks strategies, systems, alliances, and formulas through which uncertain outcomes might somehow be mastered.

Before Balak ever laid the first stone upon an altar, another altar had already been built within his heart. It was there that his theology had gone astray. He believed God could be approached as earthly kings were approached—with gifts, negotiation, and persuasion. He had not yet discovered what Israel had been learning for forty years in the wilderness: God is not manipulated by human effort. He reveals Himself according to His own covenant, His own character, and His own sovereign purpose.

Christ Revealed

At first glance, Jesus Christ seems absent from these opening verses, yet the Gospel quietly casts its shadow across the entire scene. Balak looked across the valley and saw danger. God looked across the valley and saw covenant. That difference anticipates the Cross itself. Humanity looked at Calvary and saw defeat, shame, and death. God looked at Calvary and saw redemption, reconciliation, and the fulfillment of every promise He had spoken since Eden.

Fear always misinterprets God's activity because fear judges by appearances. Revelation, however, allows us to see history through the eyes of God. Throughout Scripture the Lord continually invites His people to exchange fearful perception for revealed truth. The

Gospel is not merely God's answer to sin; it is God's answer to humanity's distorted vision.

Theological Reflection

The opening verses of this account reveal something profound about the character of God. Long before Balak devised a strategy, long before Balaam entered the story, and long before the first altar was built, God's covenant with Israel already stood secure. Divine purpose never rested upon Balak's understanding. It rested upon God's faithfulness.

This is the great comfort of every believer. God's promises are not sustained by our ability to defend them. They stand because they proceed from His unchanging nature. The God who called Abraham, preserved Israel, fulfilled His promises in Christ, and poured out His Spirit at Pentecost has never governed His Kingdom according to human ambition. He remains the God of covenant, revelation, and grace.

Revival Reflection

Perhaps the first altar every believer must examine is not one constructed from stone, wood, or sacrifice, but the invisible altar quietly erected within the human heart. Long before Balak's servants gathered stones upon the mountains of Moab, fear had already built an altar inside the king himself. It was there that ambition

was born. It was there that control replaced surrender. Every physical altar that followed simply revealed what had already taken root within his soul.

The same struggle continues in every generation. Fear still whispers that our circumstances are greater than God's promises. It magnifies uncertainty until we begin believing that if we simply pray harder, work longer, become more disciplined, or perform more faithfully, perhaps God will finally respond to our efforts. Without realizing it, we begin attempting to accomplish through human determination what God has always intended to accomplish through His grace.

Revelation speaks a better word. It reminds us that before we ever reached toward God, He had already reached toward us. Before we ever desired Him, He desired us. Before we ever sought His face, He had already begun revealing Himself through His Word, through His covenant, and ultimately through His Son. The Gospel is not the story of man climbing high enough to find God; it is the story of God descending into our brokenness to reveal Himself. That single revelation transforms fear into faith, striving into surrender, religion into relationship, and human ambition into humble obedience.

Closing Meditation

Balak stood upon a mountain believing the greatest problem before him was Israel. He could not yet see

that his greatest obstacle was not the nation in the valley below but the misunderstanding within his own heart. Every mountain we climb in an attempt to control God ultimately reveals how little we understand Him. Before smoke ever rises from seven altars, before Balaam speaks a single word, and before heaven answers, God is already preparing to reveal the truth that will echo throughout this entire journey:

Seven altars cannot buy one word from God.

End of sample

Thank you for reading the opening of
Seven Altars Can’t Buy One Word from God.

The full edition is being prepared
for publication.

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